PRACTITIONER HANDBOOKS · B1

Lodge Mentor's Guide

The full guide for appointed Lodge Mentors in the Masonic Province of Hertfordshire: the roles, the principles, the member's journey stage by stage, learning, One Journey, retention, escalation, migration, working with other officers, Provincial support, and the Lodge Mentor's year.

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Companions	Lodge Mentor's Short Guide (B1a) · Personal Mentor's Guide · The Hertfordshire Mentoring Handbook (B0)

Foreword

Firstly, congratulations on being appointed Lodge Mentor.

I believe the Lodge Mentor has one of the most important roles in any Lodge. Not because of the rank or title that comes with it, but because of the difference you can make to a Brother's experience of Freemasonry. Helping someone feel welcome, supporting them as they learn and develop, and making sure they continue to enjoy their Freemasonry are all important parts of what we do.

This guide has been put together to help you in that role. It isn't intended to tell you exactly how to do things or give you another set of rules to follow. Instead, it provides practical advice, ideas and guidance that you can adapt to suit your Lodge and its members.

Every Lodge is different, and so is every Brother. Some will want to get involved in everything from day one, while others will prefer to take their time. Some will be keen to learn ritual and progress through the offices, while others will simply enjoy attending meetings and spending time with friends. There is no single approach that works for everyone, and good mentoring is about recognising those differences and providing the right support at the right time.

One thing I am particularly keen to emphasise is that mentoring doesn't stop once a Brother has completed his Third Degree. It should be part of his entire Masonic journey, from those first conversations before joining, through his degrees, progression into office, the Chair and beyond. Equally, we shouldn't forget those who have been members for many years or those joining us from another Lodge. Everyone should feel that they have someone they can turn to for advice, guidance or simply a conversation.

In Hertfordshire, we have developed a set of Mentoring Principles, which you will find in Section 3. These provide the foundation for our approach across the Province. The rest of this guide looks at how we can put those principles into practice, both at Lodge meetings and, just as importantly, in the weeks and months between them.

I also want to make it clear that you are not expected to do everything yourself. Successful mentoring is a team effort, involving the Lodge Mentor, Personal Mentors, the Almoner, other Lodge Officers and the wider membership. Your role is to help bring that support together and make sure nobody gets overlooked.

The Provincial Mentoring Team is here to support you as well. We have a growing range of guides and resources, regular mentoring calls, opportunities to share ideas with other Lodge Mentors and people you can contact whenever you need a bit of advice. Please make use of them. If something isn't working in your Lodge, or you're unsure how best to support a Brother, pick up the phone and have a conversation. We are all learning from one another.

Finally, I would encourage you not to lose sight of something that I believe is fundamental to good mentoring: Freemasonry should be enjoyable.

As our Provincial Grand Mentor regularly reminds us, *"Freemasonry must be fun."*

We can sometimes get caught up in ceremonies, offices, administration and everything else that goes into running a Lodge. All of those things are important, but we must remember why our members joined in the first place and what makes them want to keep coming back.

A Brother who enjoys his Freemasonry is more likely to attend. A Brother who attends is more likely to get involved. And a Brother who feels involved, valued and part of his Lodge is far more likely to remain a member for many years to come.

That, for me, is what good mentoring is really about.

Thank you for taking on the role and for the time and effort you put into supporting your fellow Brethren. It really does make a difference, not just to individual members, but to the future of Freemasonry across Hertfordshire.

Wes Pierce

Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor, Province of Hertfordshire

September 2026

1 Introduction

This guide has been prepared by the Provincial Grand Mentor's office to help Lodge Mentors carry out their role effectively and with confidence. It sits within UGLE's Building Together framework, in which mentoring owns the ENGAGE theme, and it aligns fully with the Provincial Mentoring Framework.

The guide does not replace Lodge autonomy or individual judgement. Lodges differ in character, size and tradition, and what works in one may need adapting in another. This is not a rulebook. It is a practical framework and a source of prompts and ideas.

Mentoring in Hertfordshire rests on a simple idea: every member, at every stage of his Masonic journey, deserves to be properly prepared, thoughtfully guided, actively supported and continuously enlightened. That is not the job of one man. It is a shared Lodge culture, co-ordinated by the Lodge Mentor.

1.1 Who this guide is for

It is written for appointed Lodge Mentors. It will also be useful to:

- Personal Mentors supporting individual members (who have their own companion, the Personal Mentor's Guide)
- Worshipful Masters and Wardens, who oversee the welfare of the Lodge
- Lodge Membership Officers, Almoners and Secretaries working alongside the mentoring team
- Any experienced Mason supporting the Lodge's newer members

1.2 Abbreviations used in this guide

LM	Lodge Mentor
PM	Personal Mentor
ProvGMen	Provincial Grand Mentor
PGM	Provincial Grand Master
UGLE	United Grand Lodge of England
WM	Worshipful Master
EA / FC / MM	Entered Apprentice / Fellow Craft / Master Mason

LoI	Lodge of Instruction
DC	Director of Ceremonies
RA	Royal Arch
DAWG	Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team

2 Understanding the Roles

Good mentoring works best when everyone understands their role and works together. Within the Lodge, there are two main roles: the Lodge Mentor and the Personal Mentor. Both are important, but they have different responsibilities.

There is also a Provincial Mentoring Team available to provide advice, guidance and support whenever it is needed.

The important thing is that we work together, avoid duplicating effort and, above all, make sure that no Brother is overlooked.

2.1 The Lodge Mentor

2. Who Does What?

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2.1 The Lodge Mentor

As Lodge Mentor, your role is to oversee and co-ordinate mentoring within your Lodge. That doesn't mean you need to personally mentor every Brother, nor should you be expected to.

Your responsibility is to make sure that mentoring is taking place, that Personal Mentors have the support they need and that members are receiving the right guidance throughout their Masonic journey.

In practice, this means:

- **Appointing Personal Mentors:** Making sure every new or joining member has a suitable Personal Mentor as early as possible, ideally before they join.
- **Supporting Personal Mentors:** Helping them understand their responsibilities, providing a copy of the Personal Mentor's Guide and being available when they need advice.
- **Keeping track of progress:** Making sure a Personal Mentoring Plan is in place for each Brother receiving mentoring support, and reviewing it regularly to see how things are going.
- **Looking at the bigger picture:** Having a good understanding of how mentoring is working across the Lodge, recognising where things are going well and where a little more attention might be needed.
- **Keeping in touch with the Province:** Acting as the main point of contact for Provincial mentoring matters, attending the monthly mentoring calls where possible and sharing relevant information with your Lodge.
- **Recognising when help is needed:** Raising any concerns with the Worshipful Master or seeking guidance from the Provincial Mentoring Team when appropriate.
- **Maintaining continuity:** Keeping straightforward, secure records so that important information isn't lost, particularly when the time comes to hand over to your successor.
- **Keeping mentoring on the agenda:** Taking the opportunity, at least once a year, to remind the Lodge what mentoring is about, why it matters and how everyone can play their part.

Where possible, it is worth encouraging a Lodge Mentor to remain in post for a reasonable period, ideally three to five years. This gives you time to build relationships, develop a good understanding of the members and establish a mentoring approach that works for your Lodge.

It is also worth thinking about who might take over from you in the future. Involving another Brother in what you do will help make the eventual handover much easier.

Remember

Your role is to make sure mentoring happens, not to do everything yourself.

There will be plenty of experienced Brethren in your Lodge who can offer support, share their knowledge or simply spend time with a newer member. Making good use of those Brethren is one of the most valuable things you can do as Lodge Mentor.

The more mentoring becomes part of everyday Lodge life, rather than the responsibility of one person, the more effective it will be.

2.2 The Personal Mentor

While the Lodge Mentor oversees mentoring across the Lodge, the Personal Mentor provides the individual support.

He is the Brother who takes a new or joining member under his wing, helps him settle in, answers his questions and provides a familiar face as he finds his feet in Freemasonry.

For many new members, their Personal Mentor will be one of the most important people in their early Masonic experience. Having someone they feel comfortable speaking to, particularly when they are unsure about something, can make a real difference.

The Personal Mentor doesn't need to be a senior Mason or someone who knows every detail of Freemasonry. In fact, the ability to listen, be approachable and make someone feel at ease is often far more important than the number of years they have been a member.

When choosing a Personal Mentor, look for someone who:

- **Knows the Lodge:** Has enough experience to help a new member understand how things work, who people are and what to expect.
- **Is a good match:** Has a personality and approach that will suit the member. Shared interests or similar backgrounds can sometimes help build that relationship.
- **Has the time:** Is willing to keep in touch, including between Lodge meetings, rather than only speaking to the Brother when they meet in the Lodge room.
- **Is approachable:** Someone who listens, is patient and makes it easy for a Brother to ask questions, however simple they might seem.
- **Can offer guidance without taking over:** Encourages the member to learn and discover things for himself, rather than telling him what to do at every stage.

- **Knows when to ask:** Is comfortable admitting when he doesn't know an answer and is willing to find out rather than guessing.

One of the things I would encourage Lodge Mentors to think carefully about is matching the right Personal Mentor to the right Brother.

It is easy to appoint someone simply because they are available or have held a senior office, but that doesn't necessarily make them the best person for the job.

Think about their personalities, interests, where they live and how much time they can realistically give. A good mentoring relationship should feel natural, and ideally develop into a lasting friendship.

The Proposer will often be a good choice, particularly where an existing friendship or relationship has already been established. However, that won't always be the case, and there is nothing wrong with choosing someone else if you feel they would be a better fit.

It is also important that Personal Mentors understand they are not expected to have all the answers. Freemasonry has a great deal to learn, and even the most experienced Mason will occasionally come across something he doesn't know.

There is nothing wrong with saying, *"I'm not sure, but let's find out."*

The Lodge Mentor, other experienced Brethren and resources such as Solomon are all there to help. What matters is that the information we share is accurate and that we don't pass on something simply because it's what we've always been told.

Remember

A good Personal Mentor isn't necessarily the Brother who knows the most about Freemasonry.

It is the Brother who makes someone feel comfortable, takes an interest in them and is willing to give a little of his time to help them enjoy their membership.

2.3 The Provincial Mentoring Team

As Lodge Mentor, you are not expected to deal with everything on your own. The Provincial Mentoring Team is there to support you, share ideas and help whenever you need guidance.

The team consists of the Provincial Grand Mentor, the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor and assistants.

We recognise that every Lodge operates slightly differently, and there will be many examples of good mentoring already taking place across Hertfordshire. Part of the Provincial team's role is to understand what works, share those ideas and help other Lodges benefit from that experience.

If you're unsure about something, have a member who needs additional support or simply want to talk through an idea, please get in touch.

Sometimes a quick conversation with someone who has dealt with a similar situation is all that's needed.

You can find more information about the Provincial Mentoring Team, the resources available and how to access support in Section 11.

Ultimately, we are all working towards the same thing: helping our Brethren enjoy their Freemasonry, feel part of their Lodge and get the most from their membership.

3 The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles

In Hertfordshire, we have four Mentoring Principles that underpin everything we are trying to achieve across the Province.

They provide a common approach to mentoring, whether you are a Lodge Mentor, a Personal Mentor or simply a Brother helping another member.

The principles are deliberately straightforward. They aren't intended to create more administration or give Lodges another set of rules to follow. Instead, they help us focus on what really matters: making sure every Brother feels welcome, enjoys his Freemasonry and has the support and encouragement he needs throughout his Masonic journey.

The four principles below are taken directly from **The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles**, which provides the foundation for our mentoring work across the Province. The wording is reproduced exactly so that we have a consistent message in all our mentoring guides and resources.

Our Vision

"Every member, in every Lodge, experiences Freemasonry as welcoming, supportive, engaging, and personally rewarding"

Mentoring in Hertfordshire is a culture, not a programme. It supports a Brother from his first enquiry into Freemasonry through every stage of his Masonic journey - properly prepared, thoughtfully guided, actively supported, and continuously enlightened - so that no Brother walks alone.

PREPARE	Ensuring members are ready for each stage of their Masonic journey. This begins before interview and continues through practical preparation for ceremonies, office, and progression - ensuring members understand what to expect before it happens.
GUIDE	Providing accurate, clear, and timely information and support. Good guidance is honest and grounded in authoritative sources. It dispels myths, answers questions openly, and helps members navigate an unfamiliar world with confidence - without creating dependency.
SUPPORT	Being present, responsive, and compassionate throughout. Support is not only practical; it is relational. Members who feel cared for and valued are far more likely to remain engaged and committed. The question is always "How can we help?" - never "Why aren't you attending?"
ENLIGHTEN	Deepening understanding, curiosity, and enjoyment of Freemasonry. Mentoring does not end with the Third Degree; it is a lifelong opportunity to help Brethren appreciate Freemasonry - its purpose, traditions and meaning - rather than simply learn information.

Putting the Principles into Practice

Although we describe them as four separate principles, they aren't four stages that a Brother works through, or boxes that need to be ticked.

Prepare, Guide, Support and Enlighten should be happening throughout a Brother's Masonic journey, often at the same time.

For example, a newly initiated Brother might need help understanding what happened during his ceremony, some guidance on what to expect at his next meeting and encouragement to get involved in Lodge activities. At the same time, he may simply appreciate a friendly phone call to see how he is getting on.

A Brother preparing to take office might need help learning his part, an explanation of his responsibilities and reassurance that nobody expects him to get everything right first time.

Equally, a Past Master who has been a member for thirty years may still benefit from encouragement to explore another aspect of Freemasonry, take on a different role or simply reconnect with the Lodge if he hasn't been attending regularly.

All of these are examples of mentoring in practice.

One thing we are particularly keen to encourage is that mentoring becomes something the whole Lodge takes responsibility for, rather than something left to the Lodge Mentor.

The Lodge Mentor helps organise and co-ordinate the approach. Personal Mentors provide more individual support. But every Brother has a part to play.

It might be something as simple as introducing yourself to a new member, inviting someone to sit with you at the Festive Board, offering to help a Brother learn a piece of ritual or checking in with someone you haven't seen for a while.

None of these things requires an appointment or a title, but they can make a tremendous difference to how someone feels about their Lodge.

We often say that we are all mentors to others in Freemasonry, and I think that is something worth remembering.

If we can build a culture where members naturally look out for one another, share their knowledge and encourage each other, good mentoring becomes part of everyday Lodge life.

And when Brethren feel welcome, involved and valued, they are far more likely to enjoy their Freemasonry and remain active members.

Ultimately, that is what these four principles are intended to achieve.

4 The Member's Journey

Mentoring follows the member through his Masonic life and adapts to his needs at each stage. The pages that follow set out the key moments and the actions and conversations good mentoring should include. They are prompts, not a checklist to be ticked. The Personal Mentor's Guide covers the same journey from the one-to-

one perspective, and the Stage Checklists give one-page versions for the night itself.

Two rules run through every stage. First, there should never be any surprises: a member should always know what is coming next. Second, the member sets the pace, never the calendar.

4.1 Before Initiation

Mentoring begins before the ballot, ideally from the moment a candidate is first proposed. The Lodge Mentor should be involved early, working with the Proposer, Seconder and Secretary.

Before the ballot

- Encourage the Lodge to get to know the candidate at informal social occasions before the formal interview, so that he arrives for interview among friends rather than strangers
- Ensure the interview is honest and covers the practical matters: costs and subscriptions, meeting frequency and timing, the Lodge of Instruction, the time commitment if he takes office, and the importance of a supportive partner or family
- Be open about what Freemasonry is and is not. A well-informed candidate makes a better long-term member
- Make sure he has introductory literature before the ballot

After the ballot

- Assign a Personal Mentor as soon as possible after election, and open his Personal Mentoring Plan
- Meet the candidate socially, with other members, as often as practical before his Initiation
- Involve his partner or family in social occasions where appropriate
- Prepare him for the evening: timings, what he will be asked to do, what to wear, what to bring, and the general shape of the evening, without spoiling the ceremony itself
- Contact him the day before, or on the day, to reassure him and answer last-minute questions

> **Good practice.** Introduce the candidate to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon immediately before the ceremony. Both can reassure him and make sure he does not feel isolated while he is outside the Lodge.

4.2 The Initiation and immediately after

The evening of Initiation is one of the most formative experiences of a member's Masonic life. Everything that happens, in the ceremony, at the Festive Board and in the days that follow, shapes his early impression of Freemasonry.

During the evening

- Seat the Personal Mentor next to, or as close as possible to, the Initiate so he can offer quiet reassurance and explanation as the evening unfolds
- Prepare him for the Festive Board: how Masonic Fire works, the order of toasts, and what he will be expected to say. Ask if he needs help with the speech in advance
- The first Festive Board can be daunting, make sure he is never left alone

Shortly after Initiation

A quick call or message within a day or two, and a proper one-to-one before the next Lodge meeting. That first meeting is critical. It should be relaxed, at his pace, and include:

- An open question first: "What did you make of the evening?" Then let him talk
- A review of the ceremony: what happened and, in general terms, why
- A chance to ask anything at all
- Introduce the Fleet House Light Blue Club
- An introduction to the test questions he will need before his Passing, and how he will be helped to learn them
- A look through the Initiate's Guide
- How the Lodge is organised: officers, their roles, how to recognise them, and where the Lodge sits within Province and Grand Lodge
- Masonic etiquette: the Risings, conduct at the Festive Board, and the customs of the Lodge
- An introduction to the charitable work of Freemasonry
- Solomon, and how to sign up

> **Key principle.** The role of Brother Initiate can feel very lonely. Unfamiliar sights, unfamiliar language, unfamiliar people. Our task as mentors is to dispel that strangeness as quickly as possible, through warmth, explanation and genuine friendship.

4.3 Between degrees

When the Lodge meets in a higher degree and the Entered Apprentice cannot be present, the evening is an ideal opportunity for structured Masonic education, not dead time. The Personal Mentor should:

- Arrange to meet him on the evening of the Lodge meeting, or at another convenient time, for companionship and learning
- Use the time for Masonic history, the meaning of the First Degree, the structure of Freemasonry, or whatever he is curious about
- Encourage he is using Solomon and has begun to explore it
- Keep in frequent, informal contact. Regular check-ins make the difference between a member who feels included and one who quietly drifts

The Lodge Mentor should watch this period closely. National evidence shows that many losses occur within two years of Initiation, often before Raising, and that candidates initiated in the spring are at extra risk because the summer break interrupts their early participation. Plan deliberate summer contact and social touchpoints for spring Initiates.

4.4 After Passing to Fellow Craft

The Second Degree is sometimes called the forgotten degree. It should not be. After his Passing the Personal Mentor should:

- Review the ceremony with him: what happened and what it signifies
- Talk through the differences he will have noticed between his Initiation and his Passing, and why they exist
- Discuss the Liberal Arts and Sciences and their relevance to everyday life
- Make sure he can give the Sign, Token and Word of a Fellow Craft correctly, as taught in the Lodge
- Explain the different aprons and what they signify
- Encourage visiting

- Begin preparing him for the Third Degree, including the test questions, at his pace

> **Good practice.** Arrange for the Fellow Craft to witness a Passing in another Lodge as soon as convenient. Seeing the ceremony from the outside deepens understanding enormously.

4.5 After Raising to Master Mason

The Raising is a milestone, but it is a beginning, not a summit. The months after the Third Degree are one of the two recognised drop-out windows. Mentoring should intensify here, not fade.

After the Raising

- Review the ceremony: the essence of the Third Degree and its central teaching
- Make sure he can give the Grip and the Five Points of Fellowship correctly, as taught in the Lodge
- Explain how to sign in when visiting, and the caution needed in Lodges under other Constitutions
- Explain that Lodges work differently
- Cover the etiquette of responding to the Visitors' Toast, and the importance of thanking hosts promptly

In the months that follow

- Encourage regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction
- Encourage visiting across the Province and beyond; offer to go with him the first time
- Introduce him to Provincial events, the Fleet House Light Blues Club and DAWG
- Support him in exploring whatever in Freemasonry interests him
- Make sure the Royal Arch has been explained as the completion of his journey, on his timing (Section 6)
- Begin gentle, open conversations about whether and when he might like to take office. Both answers are valid

4.6 Into progressive office

When a member is offered his first office, the Lodge Mentor and Personal Mentor should make sure he is properly supported:

- Confirm he is genuinely ready and willing. Never pressure a member into office before he is confident
- Make sure he understands the responsibilities, time commitment and ritual requirements of the office
- Arrange ritual support from experienced members, and make sure he knows the DC and Preceptor are on his side
- Support regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction
- Check in as he progresses, and be alert to anxiety or fading confidence

Progressive office is exciting, but it can be daunting, particularly for members who lack confidence in ritual or public speaking. Support must be available, not assumed. Readiness runs in both directions: the Brother pushed too early and the capable Brother left waiting both need your attention (see 8.2).

4.7 The Chair and beyond

Mentoring does not end when a member becomes Worshipful Master, or when he leaves the Chair. Every stage brings new experiences and new questions.

- A Master Elect benefits from preparation for the year: managing the Lodge, leading meetings, working with his officers, and looking after his own wellbeing
- From Installation day, prepare him for what follows the Chair. The year after the Chair is the second recognised risk window
- Past Masters often feel a loss of purpose. Keep them Included, Involved and Interested: a role, a project, a Brother to mentor
- Members taking on Provincial or other wider roles should be prepared and supported
- Long-standing members develop new questions about symbolism, history or the Royal Arch. Welcome them

> **Key principle.** Every Brother should want others to succeed, in Freemasonry and in life. The best Lodges are those in which experienced members invest in those coming behind them. Past Masters make excellent Personal Mentors. That is mentoring in its truest sense.

4.8 Joining members, re-joiners and dual members

Not every new member is an Initiate. A Brother who joins from another Lodge arrives as an experienced Mason but a stranger to this one, and the risk is that the Lodge assumes he needs nothing. He does. He needs a friend, and he needs to learn how this Lodge works.

Joining members

- Assign a Personal Mentor
- Open a Personal Mentoring Plan and mark it as a joining-member route; the early-degree stages do not apply
- Cover the things nobody thinks to explain: the Lodge's customs and working, dining arrangements, dress, who is who, how the Lodge communicates, and the calendar
- Ask what he wants from his membership. Some join for office, some for friendship, some for a quieter Masonic life. Do not assume, and do not press him into the progression ladder
- If he has come from another Province, he may be arriving through the Member Migration Process. Close the loop with the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the sending Lodge knows he has landed safely
- Introduce him at the Festive Board and make sure he is not sitting alone for his first few meetings

Re-joiners

- A Brother returning after resignation is a success story in the making. Understand, gently, why he left and what is different now
- Treat him as a joining member for mentoring purposes, and be alert to whatever caused the earlier loss recurring
- He may have missed changes in the Lodge, the Province or Grand Lodge practice. Bring him up to date without fuss

Dual and multiple members

- Watch the diary. A Brother with two Lodges can be asked to do too much by both. Talk to his other Lodge Mentor where you can
- Never let two Lodges progress him to office at the same time unless he genuinely wants it
- Make sure he still feels he belongs here, and is not simply a visitor with a subscription

5 Supporting Learning

One of the most important functions of mentoring is helping members learn and understand Freemasonry. Accurate, consistent learning builds confidence and enjoyment. Inaccurate or inconsistent learning breeds confusion, frustration and disengagement. Mentoring supports two kinds of learning.

5.1 Guided learning

Guided learning is what a member needs to know to take part fully and confidently in Lodge life:

- The signs, tokens and words of each degree, as taught in the Lodge
- Test questions and answers before progression
- Ritual and ceremony relevant to an office or degree
- Lodge etiquette, protocol and procedure
- The structure of English Freemasonry and the role of its officers

Guided learning should be planned, accurate and delivered or overseen by those with the experience to do it well. The Lodge of Instruction is the natural home for it. Lodge Mentors should work with the Preceptor and DC so that LoI is welcoming to junior Brethren and not only a rehearsal for officers.

5.2 Personal learning

Personal learning is what the individual member wishes to explore for his own curiosity and fulfilment: the history and symbolism of Freemasonry; the meaning of ceremony, regalia and ritual; the story of the Lodge itself; the Royal Arch and the rest of Pure Antient Masonry. It is led by his interests, continues throughout his Masonic life, and should be welcomed. Interpretation is offered with humility: different Brethren read a symbol differently, and none of them wrongly.

5.3 Solomon and Archway

Solomon is UGLE's online learning platform and the primary authoritative resource for members in England. Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors should use it and point members to it.

- Solomon contains accurate, UGLE-approved material for every stage
- It is available online at solomon.ugle.org.uk; where digital access is difficult, print from it

- Use it alongside, never instead of, face-to-face conversation
- Archway, UGLE's developing Royal Arch resource, sits alongside Solomon for One Journey material. Check its current status with the Provincial Office

Steer members away from unverified online content, speculation and material from other Masonic traditions. When in doubt, refer to Solomon or ask the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.

6 The Royal Arch: One Journey

UGLE describes the Royal Arch as the completion of Pure Antient Masonry, and encourages Master Masons to complete that journey before joining other orders. Hertfordshire's approach is called One Journey. Its purpose is education and timing, never pressure. The most common failure is a Brother who reaches the Chair having never had the Royal Arch explained to him, and who then hears it as a sales pitch rather than the natural close of the path he began on his Initiation night.

6.1 Four bridging points

Mentoring closes the gap between Craft and Chapter at four moments. The Lodge Mentor makes sure each one happens.

When	What the mentor does
At Initiation	The Provincial Welcome Letter and the Personal Mentor's early conversations frame Freemasonry as a four-part journey from the start. The Royal Arch is never a surprise.
Through progression	As he is passed and raised, the mentor places each step in the wider journey, so the Royal Arch is anticipated rather than introduced cold.
Around the Third Degree	The mentor makes sure he knows UGLE's encouragement to complete the journey in Pure Antient Masonry, and knows that the choice, and its timing, are his alone.
Through the Royal Arch Representative	Every Craft Lodge has one. The Lodge Mentor works with him so that information is shared, accurate and consistent, and so that a Brother who expresses interest is introduced to a Chapter warmly.

6.2 Two rules for the conversation

> **Timing, not inevitability.** Introduce the Royal Arch when the member has consolidated his understanding of the Craft, has shown curiosity or asked questions, and has room in his life for a further commitment. Never rush it, and never assume it.

> **Information, not recruitment.** Tell him clearly what the Royal Arch is, what to expect, and what the time and cost involve. Reassure him that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself. He must never be made to feel an incomplete Freemason without it.

6.3 Why it matters for retention

Members who join the Royal Arch are demonstrably more likely to stay engaged with their Craft Lodges. A Brother who sees a path ahead of him stays; one who believes he has reached the end of the road is the one most at risk. One Journey therefore serves the same end as everything else in this guide.

The Provincial Mentoring Team works with the Provincial Grand Chapter so that One Journey messaging is shared, not parallel. A bridge built from only one side does not meet in the middle. The Provincial Grand Mentor's office can advise on any specific situation.

7 Retention and Warning Signs

Most resignations are preceded by warning signs. Noticed early and acted on warmly, they can be addressed before disengagement becomes irreversible. Where exit conversations happen, roughly one resignation in three is recovered. Early action prevents resignations; late action rarely does.

This section is a summary. The Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide is the owner-document, covering the rules on resignation (Rule 183), unattached Brethren (Rule 127), the retrieval conversation and lessons learned. The Warning Signs card carries the essentials on one page for every mentor's pocket.

7.1 The pattern is the signal

Risk shows as a break in a member's own pattern, not as a low absolute level of attendance. A Brother who has always attended twice a year is content; a stalwart who stops coming is not. The Secretary's attendance record, shared after each meeting, is your early-warning system, and the Personal Mentor is the person who will hear the real reason behind the stated one.

Watch for	Signs
Attendance patterns	Two or more consecutive meetings missed without explanation; habitual late arrival or early departure; attending only Installations or social events; ceasing to visit; a summer absence that extends into autumn.
Participation changes	Reluctance to accept work or office; withdrawal from conversation; missing LoI while holding office; loss of preparation where it was once a point of pride; visible unhappiness in meetings.
Communication indicators	Unanswered calls and messages; expressed frustration or disillusionment; repeated mention of time or money pressures; unfavourable comparison with other commitments; subscription arrears.

7.2 The four steps

When a Brother starts to miss meetings or appears to be losing interest, it is important that we recognise this and make contact before he becomes disconnected from the Lodge.

We have developed a simple four-step approach to help Lodge Mentors manage these situations. It isn't intended to be a formal process that every Brother must go through. In most cases, a friendly conversation is all that is needed, and the matter never needs to go any further.

The important thing is to show that we have noticed, that we care and that we are there if he needs us.

Step 1	The Personal Mentor should be the first to make contact. If a Brother unexpectedly misses a meeting, a quick phone call or message to say he was missed and check that everything is alright is often enough. If he misses two consecutive meetings, the Personal Mentor should make contact within seven days of the second meeting. This shouldn't feel like someone checking up on him or questioning why he hasn't attended. It is simply an opportunity to have a conversation, see how he is getting on and remind him that he is a valued member of the Lodge.
Step 2	If the Personal Mentor feels that a Brother may be becoming less engaged, or there is something affecting his enjoyment of Freemasonry, the Lodge Mentor should become involved. The first thing to understand is what might be behind the situation. It could be work or family commitments, the cost of attending, difficulties with an office or simply that the Brother isn't getting what he expected from his membership. We should also be prepared to consider whether there is something the Lodge could do differently. The Lodge Mentor should work with the Personal Mentor to agree any appropriate support, keep a brief and discreet record of what has been discussed and, importantly, follow up with the Brother. **There is little point in asking someone what we can do to help if we then do nothing with the answer.**
Step 3	Sometimes a concern may need the involvement of the Worshipful Master, particularly where it relates to the way the Lodge operates, a Brother's progression through office or a difficulty involving another member. In these circumstances, a conversation with the Worshipful Master may help find a way forward. Where there are personal or welfare concerns, the Lodge Almoner should also be involved, with appropriate sensitivity and discretion. The aim isn't to turn a relatively minor issue into a formal matter. It is about making sure the right people are involved and that we do what we reasonably can to support the Brother.

Step 4	There may be occasions when the Lodge has done what it can, but a Brother would benefit from some additional support or an independent conversation. This is where the Provincial Mentoring Team can help. It may be that a fresh perspective is useful, that there is an issue which is difficult to resolve within the Lodge, or that a Brother might be better suited to another Lodge whose meeting arrangements, membership or approach would be a better fit. In these circumstances, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office for advice and assistance. Asking the Province for support isn't an admission that mentoring has failed. Quite the opposite. It shows that we are putting the interests of the Brother first. We would much rather help someone find a way to continue enjoying Freemasonry, even if that means joining another Lodge, than see him leave the Craft altogether.

These four steps are a guide, not a rigid procedure. You don't need to work through every step if the situation can be resolved earlier, and a serious concern may need to be referred to the appropriate person straight away.

Most importantly, remember that we are dealing with people, not attendance figures.

A Brother may have perfectly good reasons for not attending, and sometimes the right thing to do is simply to give him some space while letting him know that the Lodge is there for him.

Our approach should always be supportive rather than questioning or critical.

The aim is not to pressure Brethren into attending meetings. It is to make sure that, when they are able to attend, they want to come back because they feel welcome, valued and part of their Lodge.

7.3 When a member says he may resign

A resignation letter is the beginning of a conversation, not the end of one. The Secretary acknowledges receipt only; he cannot accept a resignation. The Almoner, the Lodge Mentor and the Provincial Office are told the same day. Within the window the rules allow, the best-placed person has an unhurried, private

conversation whose purpose is understanding, not persuasion. Alternatives worth exploring include reduced involvement for a season, a leave of absence, stepping back from office, or a transfer to a Lodge that fits him better. Retrieval for the Craft matters more than retention in one Lodge.

If he still chooses to go, part with warmth and gratitude. How a Lodge handles a departure is watched by every member who stays. See the Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide, Sections 5 and 6.

> **Key principle.** The question is always "How can we help?", never "Why aren't you attending?"

8 Managing Challenges and Escalation

Lodge Mentors will meet situations that are sensitive, complex or beyond what the Lodge can reasonably resolve. Knowing when and how to escalate is part of the role.

8.1 When to seek Provincial support

Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office, when:

- A member is at significant risk of resignation and Lodge-level support has not been enough
- A situation involves welfare that may need the Almoner and Provincial officers
- A complaint or dispute in the Lodge has a mentoring dimension
- A Lodge is seeing several resignations or a pattern of early disengagement
- You would like coaching, advice or a second opinion on a difficult situation
- A member is relocating and needs migration support

Escalation is responsible mentoring. The Province exists to support Lodges, not to judge them, and all contact is treated in confidence.

8.2 Protecting members from pressure, in both directions

Pressure runs two ways. The member pushed too hard and the member left under-stretched are both at risk, and the Lodge Mentor watches for both.

The member pushed too hard

- Pressure to accept office before he feels ready or confident

- Pressure to deliver ritual beyond his current ability
- Pressure to progress through the degrees faster than he wishes
- Pressure to join the Royal Arch or other orders before the time is right
- Any behaviour that makes a member feel inadequate, unwelcome or judged

The Provincial Mentoring Framework is clear that outdated practices, including a "sink or swim" approach, discouraging visiting, or creating unnecessary mystique, run counter to UGLE guidance and the principles of Freemasonry. Where you see them, address them sensitively but directly, and escalate to the Worshipful Master or the Province if necessary.

The member left under-stretched

Less visible, and just as costly. Signs include:

- A capable Brother waiting years for a first office in a Lodge with a long queue, or with Past Masters who prefer to hold the offices themselves
- A Brother who was never asked: to visit, to take a small piece of ritual, to help with a project
- A Past Master with nothing to do, or a joining member whose experience nobody thought to use
- A Master Mason of several years who has stopped learning because nobody offered him anything to learn

What to do: talk to him about what he would like; find him a role that fits, in the Lodge, at LoI, in the Province or in mentoring itself; raise the office queue with the Worshipful Master and the DC; and if the Lodge genuinely cannot offer him what he needs, talk to the Province about whether he might flourish in a second Lodge. A Brother who is bored will leave as surely as one who is frightened.

8.3 Confidentiality and records

Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors receive sensitive information in confidence. Handle it with care:

- Record only what mentoring needs: contact details, key dates, milestones and brief notes of support given. The Personal Mentoring Plan is the record; the Personal Mentor's own notes are kept to a minimum
- The member knows a plan is kept, what it contains, and may see it on request
- Welfare matters belong to the Almoner's records. The mentoring plan notes only "referred to Almoner"

- Keep records secure, whether paper or digital, and do not circulate them
- Disclose confidential information only where the member's interests genuinely require it or where a safeguarding concern exists
- On handover, brief your successor and pass the plans on; close and securely destroy a plan within a defined period after a member resigns, migrates or dies

The Style, Terminology and Data Guide sets out the Province's data rules for mentoring records in full.

9 Migration

Relocation is one of the most common causes of loss, and one of the clearest opportunities to keep a member in Freemasonry. Migration is a continuation of mentoring, not an administrative exercise. The Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide, Section 7, is the owner-document; the essentials for the Lodge Mentor are these.

- Identify early. Mentors ask about house and job moves as a matter of course, and act on hints in conversation or changes in availability
- Have a positive conversation about continuing Freemasonry in the new area, and contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office to start the Member Migration Process
- Encourage him to stay a member here until he has joined his new Lodge, so his service is unbroken
- Stay in touch until he is settled. The sending Lodge's duty ends when he is happily at home in his new Lodge, not at the county boundary

Hertfordshire also receives migrating Brethren. Treat an inbound migrant as a joining member (4.8) and confirm his safe arrival to the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the loop is closed for the sending Lodge.

10 Working With Other Lodge Officers

Mentoring is a shared Lodge culture, and several officers hold a piece of it. The Lodge Mentor's job is to make sure the pieces connect. A short, regular conversation with each of the officers below, and a place on the agenda of the Lodge Committee, is usually all it takes.

Officer	Working together
Worshipful Master	Sets the tone of the Lodge and owns Step 3 conversations. Ask him to hear your report with the same weight as the Treasurer's, to brief the Lodge on mentoring once a year, and to protect junior Brethren from pressure.
Almoner	Leads on welfare: health, money, bereavement and family, and on contact with non-attenders and former members. Welcome new members jointly. Refer anything touching welfare to him and note only "referred to Almoner". He leads within the Rule 183 window where welfare is the cause.
Membership Officer	Holds the Lodge's membership picture and the pipeline of candidates. Agree how early you are told of a new enquiry, review joiners and leavers together at least annually, and share lessons learned.
Director of Ceremonies	Owns ceremony preparation and the culture of LoI. Agree how candidates are prepared for the practical side of each ceremony, how junior Brethren are drawn into ritual gently, and how the office queue is managed fairly.
Secretary	Holds the candidate timeline that mentoring hangs from, and the attendance record. Ask for the attendance record after each meeting, for early notice of ballots, and for same-day notice of any resignation.
Treasurer	Often the first to see hard evidence of disengagement: subscriptions falling into arrears. Agree that a first missed subscription earns a quiet word to you or the Almoner, long before any formal process.
Royal Arch Representative	One Journey's bridge in the Lodge. Agree what is said about the Royal Arch, when, and by whom, so that information is consistent and interest is met with a warm introduction to a Chapter.

Preceptor of the LoI	Where the Preceptor is not the DC, agree how new members are welcomed at LoI and how learning is paced to the member rather than the calendar.

11 Provincial Support and Resources

The Province is committed to Lodge Mentors being well supported, well equipped and well connected. The following is available to you.

Support	What it offers
Induction for new Lodge Mentors	Every newly appointed Lodge Mentor is invited to an induction covering the role, the library and how to reach the Province, and receives the Lodge Mentor's Charge. If you have not had yours, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.
Monthly mentoring call	Hosted by the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor on the first Tuesday of the month at 7pm by Teams, open to all Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors. Questions, shared experience and news from the Provincial team.
Personal Mentor workshop	A short skills workshop for Personal Mentors: asking good questions, listening, and the conversations that matter. Bring your Personal Mentors.
Combined Mentoring and Learning and Development meetings	Twice-yearly Provincial events for new Brethren, bringing together mentoring and Learning and Development. Encourage every new member to attend one.
The Visitors' Festival	Each year the Provincial team selects an exemplary First, Second and Third Degree ceremony for newly initiated, passed and raised Brethren to attend as visitors, seated with the Provincial Mentoring Team.
The Welcome Letter	Every new Initiate receives a personal letter from the Provincial team shortly after his Initiation. Make sure the Secretary has sent the details promptly.
Temple Bar Mentoring Lodge	Meets twice a year as the formal meeting point for mentoring across the Province.

DAWG	The Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team: a daily piece of Masonic interest and a community of mentors.
Solomon and Archway	UGLE's learning platform (solomon.ugle.org.uk) and its Royal Arch resource.
The mentoring library	The companion documents listed in 1.2, updated at each issue and available from the Provincial Grand Mentor's office and the Provincial website.
One-to-one support	For a specific situation, a difficult conversation or simply to think aloud, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office directly. All contact is in confidence.

12 Contact Information

Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Mark Butcher, mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk
Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Wes Pierce, asstmentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk
Provincial Office	Fleet House, 10 Parkway, St Albans, AL3 6PA
Telephone	01727 833061
Website	www.pgherts.org
Solomon (UGLE learning)	solomon.ugle.org.uk
UGLE Building Together	Via the UGLE members' website

This guide is reviewed and updated periodically. If you have suggestions for improvement, or find something that needs correcting, please contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. Corrections are collected in the Corrections Register and applied at the next issue.

13 Quick Reference: The Lodge Mentor's Year

A one-page rhythm for the role. Adapt it to your Lodge's calendar.

When	What
Every meeting	Check every candidate and new member has a Personal Mentor and a Plan. Collect the attendance record from the Secretary. Note any pattern-breaks and pass them to the Personal Mentor within seven days. Make sure no new or joining member dines alone.
Every month	Join the Provincial mentoring call. A short word with each Personal Mentor: how is he getting on, does he need anything. Check the DAWG.
Before each ceremony	Work through the Stage Checklist with the Personal Mentor. Confirm the candidate has been contacted the day before.
After each ceremony	Confirm the check-in and the first one-to-one have happened. Confirm the Welcome Letter has gone (Initiations).
Installation	Prepare the Master Elect for the year and for what follows it. Speak to the outgoing Master about his next role. Confirm a Past Master or two as Personal Mentors.
Summer	Deliberate contact and a social touchpoint for every spring Initiate and Entered Apprentice.
Once a year	Brief the whole Lodge on mentoring. Review joiners and leavers with the Membership Officer. Review records, destroy what is no longer needed, and brief your likely successor. Attend the Personal Mentor workshop with your team.

Prepare • Guide • Support • Enlighten

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